GENDER SOCIALIZATION

Sociologists and other social scientists generally attribute many of the behavioral differences between men and women to socialization.

Socialization is the process of transferring norms, values, beliefs, and behaviors to future group members.

G**ender socialization** is the process of educating and instructing potential men and women how to behave as members of that particular group.

Gender socialization is the process of learning the social expectations and attitudes associated with one's sex.

Socialization before Birth

Preparations for gender socialization begin even before the birth of the child. One of the first questions people ask of expectant parents is whether the baby will be a boy or girl. This is the beginning of a social categorization process that continues throughout life. Preparations for the birth of the child often take the expected sex into consideration, such as painting the infant's room pink or blue.

Early Life Socialization

One illustration of early life gender socialization can be seen in preschool classrooms. Children in preschool classrooms where teachers were told to emphasize gender differences saw an increase in stereotyped views of what activities are appropriate for boys or girls, while children with teachers who did not emphasize gender showed no increase in stereotyped views. This clearly demonstrates the influence of socialization on the development of gender roles; subtle cues that surround us in our everyday lives strongly influence gender socialization.

Adolescent Socialization

The process of gender socialization continues as adolescents enter the workforce. Research has found that adolescents encounter stereotypes of gendered performance in the workforce in their first jobs. First jobs are significantly segregated by sex. Girls work fewer hours and earn less per hour than boys. Hourly wages are higher in job types dominated by boys while girls are more frequently assigned housework and childcare duties. The impact of these first experiences in the professional world will shape adolescents' perspectives on how men and women behave differently in the workforce.

FAMILY/PARENTS AS AGENTS OF GENDER SOCIALIZATION

Family is the first agent of socialization. There is considerable ***evidence that parents socialize sons and daughters differently.*** Generally speaking, girls are given more latitude to step outside of their prescribed gender role (Coltrane and Adams 2004; Kimmel 2000; Raffaelli and Ontai 2004). However, differential socialization typically results in ***greater privileges afforded to boys.*** For instance, ***sons are allowed more autonomy and independence at an earlier age than daughters.*** They may be given fewer restrictions on appropriate clothing, dating habits, or curfew. ***Sons are also often free from performing domestic duties such as cleaning or cooking and other household tasks that are considered feminine.*** Daughters are limited by their ***expectation to be passive, nurturing, and generally obedient, and to assume many of the domestic responsibilities.***

Even when parents set gender equality as a goal, there may be underlying indications of inequality. For example, when dividing up household chores, ***boys may be asked to take out the garbage or perform other tasks that require strength or toughness,*** while girls may be asked to ***fold laundry or perform duties that require neatness and care.*** It has been found that ***fathers are firmer in their expectations for gender conformity than are mothers, and their expectations are stronger for sons than they are for daughters*** (Kimmel 2000). This is true in many types of activities, including ***preference of toys, play styles, discipline, chores, and personal achievements.*** As a result, boys tend to be particularly attuned to their father's disapproval when engaging in an activity that might be considered feminine, like dancing or singing (Coltrane and Adams 2008). It should be noted that parental socialization and normative expectations vary along lines of social class, race, and ethnicity. Research in the United States has shown that African American families,

for instance, are more likely than Caucasians to model an egalitarian role structure for their children (Staples and Boulin Johnson 2004).

GENDER MESSAGES IN THE FAMILY

Gender role theory posits *that* ***boys and girls learn the appropriate behavior and attitudes from the family with which they grow up***

Gender role theory posits that boys and girls learn the appropriate behavior and attitudes from the family and overall culture in which they grow up, and that non-physical gender differences are a product of socialization. Social role theory proposes that social structure is the underlying force behind gender differences, and that ***the division of labor between two sexes within a society motivates the differences in their respective behavior. Division of labor creates gender roles, which in turn, lead to gender-specific social behavior.***

Family is the most important agent of socialization because it serves as the center of a child's life. Socialization theory tells us that primary socialization – the process that occurs when a child learns the attitudes, values and actions expected of individuals within a particular culture – is the most important phase of social development, and lays the groundwork for all future socialization. Therefore, the family plays a pivotal role in the child's development, influencing both the attitudes the child will adopt and the values the child will hold. Socialization can be intentional or unintentional; the family may not be conscious of the messages it transmits, but these messages nonetheless contribute to the child's socialization. Children learn continuously from the environment that adults create, including gender norms.

For example, a ***child who grows up in a two-parent household with a mother who acts as a homemaker and a father who acts as the breadwinner may internalize these gender roles, regardless of whether or not the family is directly teaching them.*** Likewise, if parents buy dolls for their daughters and toy trucks for their sons, the children will learn to value different things.

Parents

Parents provide children with their first lessons about gender. Although gender-egalitarian attitudes have increased in many cultures over the past decades, ***parents and especially fathers typically have different expectations for their sons and daughters with regard to personality traits, abilities and activities. Parents' roles inside and outside the family also influence children's conception of gender roles. Nowadays, most women pursue jobs outside of the home, and men are increasingly involved in child care and housework.*** Interestingly, children who are raised by same-gender parents or who are exposed to father's child care involvement may be less likely to endorse gender stereotypes. In addition, father's participation in domestic duties and/or child care is associated with a lower likelihood of violence toward children. Finally, parents reinforce gender stereotypes when they provide their sons and daughters with ***different toys, or when they describe general patterns about each gender (e.g., "girls like dolls while boys like football").***

THE SCHOOL AS AN AGENT

The reinforcement of gender roles and stereotypes continues once a child reaches **school** age. Until very recently, schools were rather explicit in their efforts to stratify boys and girls. The first step toward stratification was segregation. ***Girls were encouraged to take home economics or humanities courses and boys to take shop, math, and science courses.***

Studies suggest that gender socialization still occurs in **schools** today, perhaps in less obvious forms (Lips 2004). Teachers may not even realize that they are acting in ways that reproduce gender-differentiated behaviour patterns. ***Yet, any time they ask students to arrange their seats or line up according to gender, teachers are asserting that boys and girls should be treated differently*** (Thorne 1993).

Even in levels as low as kindergarten, schools subtly convey messages to girls indicating that they ***are less intelligent or less important than boys***. For example, in a study involving teacher responses to male and female students, data indicated that ***teachers praised male students far more than their female counterparts.*** Additionally, ***teachers interrupted girls more and gave boys more opportunities to expand on their ideas*** (Sadker and Sadker 1994). Further, in social as well as academic situations, teachers have traditionally ***positioned boys and girls oppositionally—***

reinforcing a sense of competition rather than collaboration (Thorne 1993). ***Boys are also permitted a greater degree of freedom regarding rule-breaking or minor acts of deviance, whereas girls are expected to follow rules carefully and to adopt an obedient posture*** (Ready 2001). Schools reinforce the polarization of gender roles and the age-old "battle of the sexes" by positioning girls and boys in competitive arrangements.

Mimicking the actions of significant others is the first step in the development of a separate sense of self (Mead 1934). Like adults, children become agents who actively facilitate and apply normative gender expectations to those around them.

SCHOOLS / TEACHERS

Teachers/School

In addition to parents and peers, teachers are another source of gender socialization. Similar to parents, teachers have gender expectations, model gender roles, and reinforce gender-stereotypical behaviours in their classrooms. For example, educators may reinforce gender stereotypes ***by labelling and organizing students in group activities or by creating different activity centres for boys and girls.*** This gender segregation in turn highlights gender as a social category and reinforces children's gender stereotypes and avoidance of cross-gender playmates.

Although it is clear that parents, peers and teachers socialize children to think and act in gendered ways, boys' and girls' development is also influenced by biological factors, such as sex hormones, which influences children's preferences for activities. As such, gender's development might be best described as resulting from the interaction between gender socialization and biological factors.

How do teachers contribute to gender differences?

Many educators ***endorse cultural gender stereotypes (e.g., math is easier for boys than girls) and prejudices (show preferences for same-gender individuals). These biases can be explicit (e.g., consciously endorsed) or implicit (unconsciously held), and they influence teachers' classroom behaviours.***

Teachers' gender stereotypes and prejudices shape their classroom behaviour in at least three ways. ***First, teachers often model gender stereotypic behaviour. Female teachers, for example, often exhibit "math phobic" behaviours***.

Second, teachers often exhibit differential expectations for males and females (e.g., creating "dress-up" and "construction" centers and accepting—even facilitating—gender-differentiated use).

Third, teachers facilitate children's gender biases by marking gender as important by using it to label and organize students. For example, greeting children with "Good morning, boys and girls" and asking children to line up by gender.

PEER GROUPS/PEERS AS AGENT

GENDER MESSAGES FROM PEERS

Peer groups can serve as a venue for teaching gender roles, especially if conventional gender social norms are strongly held. Gender role theory posits that boys and girls learn the appropriate behavior and attitudes from the family and overall culture in which they grow up, and so non-physical gender differences are a product of socialization. Social role theory proposes that the social structure is the underlying force for gender differences. Social role theory proposes that sex-differentiated behavior is motivated by the division of labor between two sexes within a society. Division of labor creates gender roles, which in turn lead to gendered social behavior.

Peer groups can serve as a venue for teaching members gender roles. Gender roles refer to the set of social and behavioral norms that are considered socially appropriate for individuals of a specific sex in the context of a specific culture, and which differ widely across cultures and historical periods.

Through gender-role socialization, group members learn about sex differences, and social and cultural expectations. Biological males are not always masculine and biological females are not always feminine. Both genders can contain different levels of masculinity and femininity. Peer groups can consist of all males, all females, or both males and females.

Peer groups can have great influence on each other's gender role behavior depending on the amount of pressure applied. If a peer group strongly holds to a conventional gender social norm, members will behave in ways predicted by their gender roles, but if there is not a unanimous peer agreement, gender roles do not correlate with behavior. There is much research that has been done on how gender affects learning within student peer groups. The purpose of a large portion of this research has been to see how gender affects peer cooperative groups, how that affects the relationships that students have within the school setting, and how gender can then affect attainment and learning. One thing that is an influence on peer groups is student behavior.

Knowing early on that children begin to almost restrict themselves to same-gendered groups, it is interesting to see how those interactions within groups take place. ***Boys tend to participate in more active and forceful activities in larger groups, away from adults, while girls were more likely to play in small groups, near adults.*** These gender differences are also representative of many stereotypical gender roles within these same-gendered groups. The stereotypes are less prominent when the groups are mixed-gendered.

When children do not conform to the appropriate gender role, they may face negative sanctions such as being criticized or marginalized by their peers. Though many of these sanctions are informal, they can be quite severe. For example, a girl who wishes to take karate class instead of dance lessons may be called a "tomboy," facing difficulty gaining acceptance from both male and female peer groups. Boys, especially, are subject to intense ridicule for gender nonconformity.

Peers

Another important way in which children learn about gender is through ***their interactions with peers.*** During early childhood, ***children prefer to play with peers who share similar interests or who they believe share those interests, and thus are more likely to be socialized by their same gender peers.*** While ***spending time with their friends, boys and girls learn what is appropriate for one gender or the other***. This gender socialization can be direct or indirect. For example, children learn about gender stereotypes through their peers' ***direct comments (e.g., "long hair is for girls while short hair is for boys") and/or negative reactions when failing to conform to their***

gender expectations. Likewise, children learn and adopt gender-stereotypical behaviours (boy-typical versus girl-typical behaviours) as they spend more time interacting with members of their own gender.

How do peers contribute to gender differences?

Like teachers, peers contribute to the socialization of gender difference via multiple pathways. Upon entering school, children ***encounter large numbers of peers, many of whom model traditional gender behaviour, producing and reinforcing the content of gender stereotypes.***

In addition, schools are characterized by gender segregation. When many peers are available, children tend to ***select same-sex playmates***. Children's gender segregation, in turn, affects their play experiences, leading them to spend more time in stereotypic play. Furthermore, gender segregation predicts children's future conformity to gender stereotypes.

Peers also contribute to gender differentiation ***by teaching their classmates stereotypes (e.g., "Short hair is for boys not girls") and punishing them for failing to conform to stereotypes via verbal harassment and physical aggression.***

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MEDIA AS AN AGENT OF GENDER SOCIALIZATION

Mass media serves as another significant agent of gender socialization. ***In television and movies, women tend to have less significant roles and are often portrayed as wives or mothers.*** When women are given ***a lead role, they are often one of two extremes: a wholesome, saint-like figure or a malevolent, hypersexual figure*** (Etaugh and Bridges 2003). This same inequality is pervasive in children's movies (Smith 2008). Research indicates that of the 101 top-grossing G-rated movies released between 1990 and 2005, three out of four characters were male. Out of those 101 movies,

only seven were near being gender balanced, with a character ratio of less than 1.5 males per 1 female (Smith 2008).

Television commercials and other forms of advertising also reinforce inequality and gender-based stereotypes. ***Women are almost exclusively present in ads promoting cooking, cleaning, or child care–related products*** (Davis 1993). ***Think about the last time you saw a man star in a dishwasher or laundry detergent commercial.*** *In general, women are underrepresented in roles that involve leadership, intelligence, or a balanced psyche*. Of particular concern is the depiction of women in ways that are dehumanizing, especially in music videos. Even in mainstream advertising, however, themes intermingling violence and sexuality are quite common (Kilbourne 2000).

GENDER MESSAGES FROM THE MEDIA

In mass media, women tend to ***have less significant roles*** than men, and are often portrayed in ***stereotypical roles, such as wives or mothers.***

Gender socialization occurs through four major agents: *family, education, peer groups, and mass media*. Because mass media has enormous effects on our attitude and behavior, notably in regards to aggression, it is an important contributor to the socialization process. This is particularly true with regards to gender. ***In television and movies, women tend to have less significant roles than men. They are often portrayed as wives or mothers, rather than as main characters.*** When women are given a ***lead role, they are often one of two extremes: either a wholesome, saint-like figure or a malevolent, hyper-sexual figure.*** This same inequality is similarly pervasive in children's movies. Research indicates that among the 101 top-grossing, G-rated movies released between 1990 and 2005, three out of every four characters were male. Out of those movies, only seven films were even close to having a balanced cast of characters, with a ratio of less than 1.5 male characters per 1 female character.

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reference leadership, intelligence, or a balanced psyche. Particularly concerning are instances when women are depicted in dehumanizing, oppressive ways, especially in music videos. In most of the videos, women are objectified and portrayed as only existing to serve men. They wear little clothing and are walked around on leashes by men, as if they were not humans.

Gender Messages in Mass Media: ***Traditional images of American gender roles reinforce the idea that women should be subordinate to me***